Exploratory Testing & Ad-hoc Testing

Simple English notes with practical examples

1. Exploratory Testing

Definition: Exploratory Testing is a testing approach where we explore the application, understand its functionality, and test it at the same time.

Simple Explanation: When we do not know an application or a feature well, we explore it to understand how it works. While exploring, we try different inputs and actions, observe the results, and look for bugs.

Example: The Internet (Herokuapp) - Login Page

Suppose a new website, The Internet (Herokuapp), is given to us for testing. We do not know how its Login functionality works.

- Open the website and go to the Login page.
- Observe the Username field, Password field, and Login button.
- Enter a username and password, then click the Login button.
- Observe the result. Does the application log in or show an error?
- Try other ideas, such as leaving a field blank or entering an incorrect password.
- Understand the functionality while testing and report any unexpected behavior as a bug, when it is a defect.

Remember: Exploratory Testing = Explore + Understand + Test at the same time.

2. Ad-hoc Testing

Definition: Ad-hoc Testing is an informal testing approach where we test an application without predefined test cases, using our knowledge and experience to find bugs.

Simple Explanation: In Ad-hoc Testing, we use our existing knowledge and experience to test the application. Predefined test cases or test data may not be available. We test informally without following a fixed set of steps.

Example: Moving from MyCafe to Quick Heal (same domain)

- Suppose I have worked for three years in MyCafe, an antivirus company, and gained experience in antivirus testing.
- Later, I move to Quick Heal, which is also in the antivirus domain.
- My previous domain experience can help me think of useful test ideas.
- Suppose predefined test cases and test data are not provided. I use my knowledge and experience to test informally and look for bugs.

Remember: Ad-hoc Testing = Existing Knowledge + Experience + Informal Testing.

Important note: The two companies may have different products and features. Previous domain experience is helpful, but we must still understand the specific functionality and requirements of the new application before testing it.

3. Difference Between Exploratory and Ad-hoc Testing

Exploratory Testing	Ad-hoc Testing
We explore the application to understand its functionality.	We use our existing knowledge and experience to test.
We learn about the feature while testing it.	We may already know the application or similar functionality.
New test ideas are discovered while exploring.	Testing is performed informally without predefined test cases.
Learning, test design, and execution can happen together.	The tester uses personal judgment and experience to find bugs.
Example: Exploring the Herokuapp Login page.	Example: Using antivirus testing experience after moving from MyCafe to Quick Heal.

4. Quick Revision

Exploratory Testing: We explore the application, understand its functionality, and test it at the same time.

Ad-hoc Testing: We use our knowledge and experience to test informally without predefined test cases.

Key Points to Remember

- Exploratory Testing does not mean testing without thinking or planning. The tester observes, learns, creates test ideas, and checks them.
- Ad-hoc Testing is informal, but it should still be done thoughtfully to find defects.
- Test cases can be documented during Exploratory Testing. The important point is that learning and testing happen together, rather than only following fixed scripts.

End of Notes